MUSIC

FINDING HER VOICE

Popular playback singer **Jonita Gandhi** is finally expressing her true self with her debut pop EP

For Jonita Gandhi, the release of her debut pop EP *Love Like That* in January was a full circle moment. As a teenager in Toronto, Gandhi had dreams of becoming the next Beyoncé, but her popularity as a cover artist on YouTube led to her introduction in the Hindi and south Indian film industries, and she shifted her focus towards building a playback singing career.

A few years ago, the Indo-Canadian vocalist behind such hits as 'What Jhumka?' from 2023's *Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani* and 'Arabic Kuthu' from 2022's *Beast* felt a need to express her individuality. "I was a little saturated in the playback industry," says Gandhi, who made her debut with the soundtrack of 2013's *Chennai Express*. "It took me so long because [I knew] when I put my own music out, it's not going to have 100 million streams.... I realised I need to bite that bullet. I'm so happy releasing my music and not worrying about [numbers]."

At 1.8 million views on YouTube, the music video for *Love Like That*'s catchy title track, on which she duets with Pakistani-American singer Ali Sethi, has just a fraction of the plays tallied by her Bollywood or Kollywood smashes, but Gandhi is pleased with the response. "That's insane for me [considering] the fact that it's not being pushed by a Bollywood film, actors or production houses."

Further impetus to make the EP came from the comments she receives on social media about her accent. "I'm like, well, I grew up in Canada," she says. "They wouldn't know that because [when] they hear [film] music, they don't connect it to the singer."

When it came to crafting the tunes for *Love Like That*, which were created with Colombian-American producer Ariza in Los Angeles, Gandhi looked to international stars such as Spain's Rosalia and Nigeria's Burna Boy, "artists who are taking their culture to the world in a very effective and beautiful way". She says, "That's what I want to be part of for India. I want to make a song that's in Punjabi and people don't really know what I'm saying, but the production, the melody make it infectious and make them sing along. I want it to appeal to people regardless of race, language, country, background."



In Love Like That's catchy title track, **JONITA GANDHI** duets with Pakistani-American singer Ali Sethi

While the EP is based around the overarching theme of love, it also centres around the idea of duality, which Gandhi says is "ingrained" in her, and is brought out through both the music and the lyrics, which alternate between English and either Hindi, Punjabi or Urdu. For instance, the dancey 'Always & Forever (Naal Ve)' was inspired by her love for Caribbean music but also features *dholak*. The ballad 'Tu Jaane', on the other hand, talks about how spending time with your partner isn't necessarily the same as understanding their feelings.

Ultimately, Gandhi wants her non-film music to be not just an extension of herself but to also resonate with those like her, who have been brought up in a different environment but are "very, very rooted" in their culture. "I stand for a whole community of NRIs or people who are culturally confused," she says. ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

